MASS MEDIA MAKES MASS DEMOCRACY POSSIBLE

Mass media are information technologies that can quickly connect millions of people even when they are separated by vast distances. The printing press was a crucial step in that direction. Print made it possible to cheaply and quickly produce large numbers of books and pamphlets, which enabled more people to voice their opinions and be heard over a large territory, even if the process still took time. This sustained some of the first experiments in large-scale democracy, such as the Polish–Lithuanian Commonwealth established in 1569 and the Dutch Republic established in 1579.

Some may contest the characterisation of these polities as 'democratic', since only a minority of relatively wealthy citizens enjoyed full political rights. In the Polish–Lithuanian Commonwealth, political rights were reserved for adult male members of the *szlachta* – the nobility. These numbered up to 300,000 individuals, or about 5 per cent of the total adult population.[36] One of the *szlachta*'s prerogatives was to elect the king, but since voting required travelling long distances to a national convention, few exercised their right. In the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries participation in royal elections usually ranged between 3,000 and 7,000 voters, except for the 1669 elections, in which 11,271 participated.[37] While this hardly sounds democratic in the twenty-first century, it should be remembered that all large-scale democracies until the twentieth century limited political rights to a small circle of relatively wealthy men. Democracy is never a matter of all or nothing. It is a continuum, and late-sixteenth-century Poles and Lithuanians explored previously unknown regions of that continuum.

Aside from electing its king, Poland–Lithuania had an elected parliament (the Sejm) that approved or blocked new legislation and had the power to veto royal decisions on taxation and foreign affairs. Moreover, citizens enjoyed a list of inviolable rights such as freedom of assembly and freedom of religion. In the late sixteenth and early seventeenth centuries, when most of Europe suffered from bitter religious conflicts and persecutions, Poland–Lithuania was a tolerant haven, where Catholics, Greek Orthodox, Lutherans, Calvinists, Jews and even Muslims coexisted in relative harmony.[38] In 1616, more than a hundred mosques functioned in the commonwealth.[39]

In the end, however, the Polish–Lithuanian experiment in decentralisation proved to be impractical. The country was Europe's